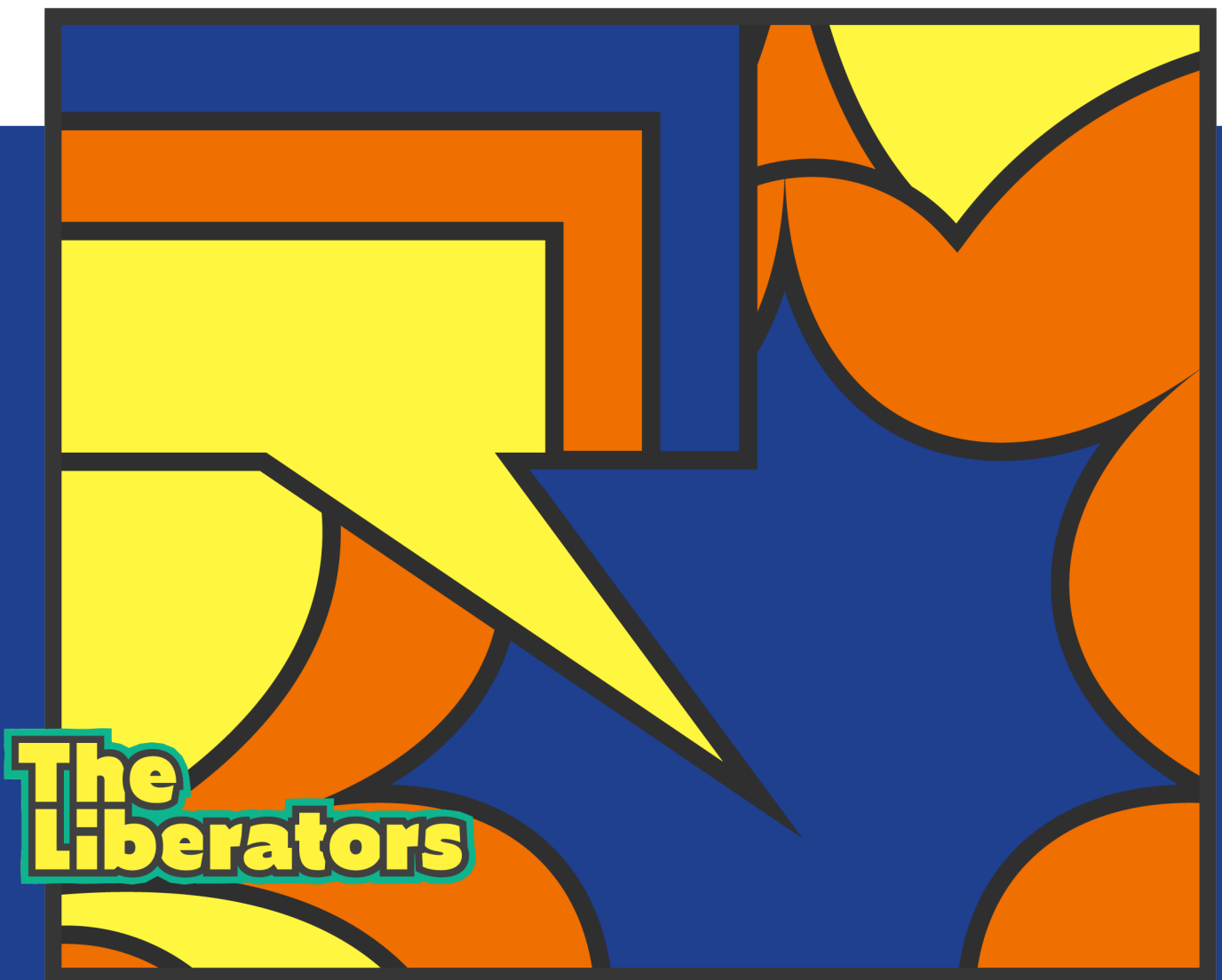


Navigate Conflict Skillfully With The Experience Wheel

A do-it-yourself workshop to learn how to address the 'elephant in the room' more effectively by clearly expressing observations, feelings, needs, and assumptions.



The Purpose Of This Workshop

Hey there,

Conflict is a natural part of working with other people. If you ask someone what conflict is, they usually explain it in terms of a verbal dispute, raised voices, slamming doors, and angry faces. But most of our conflicts are far less visible. They may not be explicitly expressed by those experiencing it, but they do influence the dynamics of a group. And either the whole group is aware of this, or some are. This is the proverbial 'Elephant In The Room'.

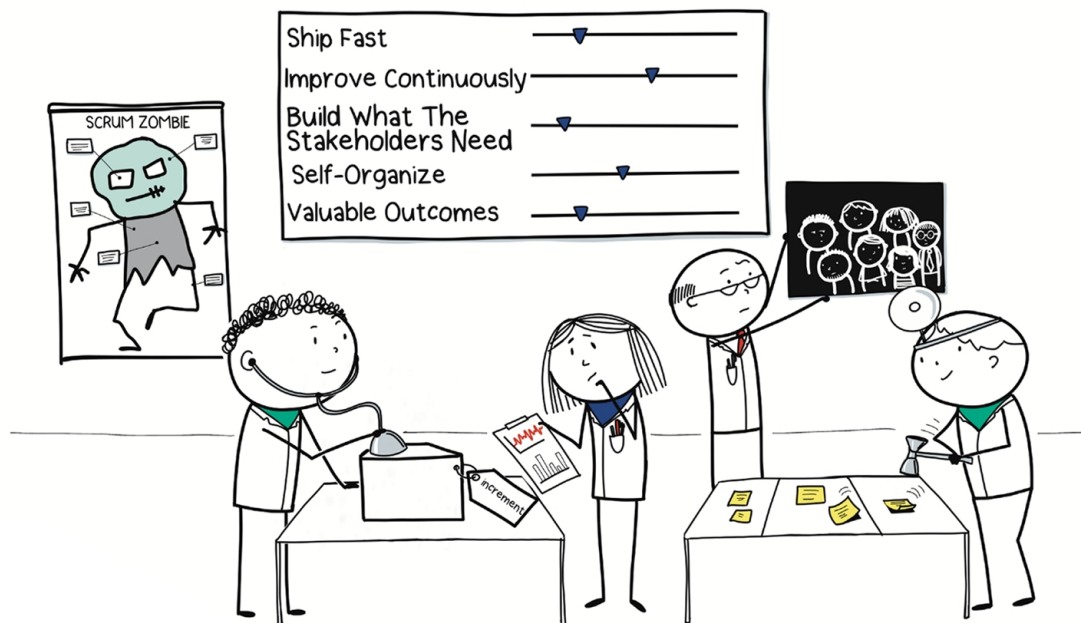
Although surfacing elephants can be messy, difficult work, it rewards teams with growth and learning when done productively. Bringing an elephant to the surface also frees up significant psychological resources; instead of complaining about their teammates at the dinner table, team members can redirect that energy into solving problems, coming up with new ideas, and rejuvenating outside of work. Teams that learn how to surface elephants can dance with conflict instead of running away from it.

We created this do-it-yourself workshop to learn how to address the elephant in the room more effectively with the Experience Wheel. It allows you to clearly express observations, feelings, needs, and assumptions and prevents jumping to wrong conclusions.

Give it a try!

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Created by Thea Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Schartau & Barry Overeem
zombiescrum.org

Flow

Step 1: Opening

3 min

Step 2: Gather Examples Of Elephants In The Room With Impromptu Networking



15 min

Step 3 - Share Common (Mis)Beliefs About Conflict

10 min

Step 4: Practice Using The Experience Wheel To Address The Elephant In The Room

30 min

Step 5: Give And Get Help With Troika Consulting



40 min

Step 6: Closing

2 min

Total duration

100 min

Difficulty / Effort

Required Skill



The facilitation of the workshop isn't difficult, using the Experience Wheel does require continuous practice.

Impact On Survival



Addressing the elephant in the room effectively prevents unhealthy conflict and improves team dynamics and productivity.



How To Prepare



Group Size

This string of Liberating Structures is feasible from 4 participants and onward.

Intended Audience

We designed this workshop for one Scrum team that wants to improve how to address the elephant in the room. It is possible to use it with multiple teams, stakeholders, or other people from the organization. You do need to pay attention to creating an environment where everyone feels safe to practice and speak up.

Virtual Delivery

Liberating Structures work well virtually. Here too, they allow you to unleash and involve everyone. What is exceptionally important, however, is that you have the right tools. Because Liberating Structures are fundamentally about breaking down large-group interactions into smaller groups, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). We also recommend a virtual whiteboard where you can collect shared insights, like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Even [Slack](#) can work.

Preparation

- Prepare slides or supporting materials for the various rounds and their invitations.
- Use tape and big post-its to create a walkable Experience Wheel on the floor. If you facilitate it virtually, add the Experience Wheel to an online workspace.
- A (virtual) canvas with the Experience Wheel. The canvas is available as a [free download](#) on our webshop.

Resources

- Blog post by Christiaan Verwijs which was used as inspiration for this DIY workshop: [Address The Elephant](#)
- Blog post: [Navigating Conflict, A Lifetime Of Work](#)
- Podcast: [Conflict Styles, What Science Says & How Liberating Structures Can Help](#)

Credits



In November 2019, we hosted a 1-day workshop on navigating tension and conflict in groups with [Julie Huffaker](#) & [Karen Dawson](#) from Deeper Funner Change and [Daniel Steinhöfer](#) from Holisticon. Attended by 55 participants, we explored how instead of 'resolving' conflict — which often isn't possible — we can navigate conflict and tension more productively instead.

This DIY workshop draws inspiration from the content and material we created together with Julie, Karen, and Daniel.



Step 1: Opening

Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then explain the purpose and start with the first structure. Superfast!

We've learned that the best way to drain energy is to talk for a long time, to ask everyone to introduce themselves, or to wait for people to drop in.



Step 2: Gather Examples Of Elephants In The Room With Impromptu Networking

At the start of this workshop, you give the participants time to get their own thinking started about elephants in the room that they've experienced. The purpose is to gather a wide range of examples that clarify what "elephants in the room" can look like. Emphasize that the participants should focus their reflections on other teams and contexts – not their current team. At this point in the workshop, you don't want to already dig into a conflict that may still be ongoing in the current team.

The Liberating Structure [Impromptu Networking](#) is used to quickly let everyone share their ideas and thoughts.

Invitation

"In your experience with working in teams, what are examples of elephants in the room you've come across? What did the elephant look like? What was the impact on the team?"

Steps

1. **5 min** First offer the invitation and give everyone a minute to silently get their thinking started about what comes to mind.
2. **3 min** Ask everyone to form pairs and let them share their ideas and thoughts with their partner. If you're doing this virtually, assign people to breakout rooms.
3. **6 min** Repeat the previous round twice more. Invite people into new pairs, and let them share their thoughts and observations while noticing patterns.
4. **10 min** When everyone is back together, ask the participants for the most interesting patterns they noticed. Capture them on a shared surface if you want to. Optionally, share examples of other common types of elephants.

Types Of Elephants

- A 'blame game' where one person or group feels they are unsuccessful because they are not getting what they need from others; while others, in turn, believe the person or group is not succeeding because of a lack of commitment or skill;
- A group or person claims 'most of the air time' by going on and on about something they think or feel, while others are bothered by that and remain silent or don't share what they really think or feel;
- Acts of 'sabotage', where one person or group actively or passively obstructs another person or group from achieving their goal, for example by not showing up for meetings or collaboration opportunities;
- 'Stepping on each other's toes' due to a lack of clarity in how roles and responsibilities are distributed or because people are "not stepping up" according to some, and the resulting frustration from that;
- There is the perception that a person or a group is 'not taking responsibility' for a decision or is 'free-riding' on the

success of others; Because the system can't see itself, everyone feels that they are 'contributing a bigger share' or working harder than the others;

- People or groups feel that others are 'not fully honest' about their motives;
- People or groups 'bask in the light' of someone they hold in high esteem, like a CEO or a manager, while others feel neglected, unheard, or unseen by this person;
- People or groups have different ideas on how to move forward, while also being frustrated by the inability of others to see their point of view (a task conflict);

One common theme is that many conflicts are essentially about our relative status in a group. Specifically, when we feel our status is lowered because others don't value us or our contributions. When there is disharmony in the social hierarchy, this causes strong emotional responses — like frustration, anger, fear, shame, sadness, or anxiety — in those experiencing the disharmony. It's a good example of how our primate brains evolved to value social hierarchies and our position in them.

Another characteristic is that conflicts are often unilateral, in that they are experienced by one party but not the others. This also depends on our personal beliefs; what one person perceives as an attack on personal status may be perceived by another as a 'good and productive debate'.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: [Rapidly share novel ideas and make personal connections with 'Impromptu Networking'](#)



Step 3 - Share Common (Mis)Beliefs About Conflict

Now that everyone has shared examples of elephants in the room, it's time for a short teaching moment. In this step, you explain four potential misunderstandings about conflict. Make sure to finish with the 4th example that explains why talking about conflict is important. This ensures a smooth connection with the next step, which is about using the Experience Wheel.

Steps

- **5 min** Explain the four potential misunderstandings about conflict. Draw inspiration from the text we've included below.
- **5 min** Answer questions that need clarification before the group moves into the next step, which is to use the Experience Wheel.



Rethink Our Beliefs On Conflict

With most conflicts living below the surface, and having a significant impact on our effectiveness, we have to develop the skills and understanding on how to surface, address and navigate them. It also requires that we change beliefs we may have about conflict:

1. Most conflicts, especially those living below the surface, **can't be solved or resolved** in the sense of arriving at a place where everyone involved is 100% happy and comfortable with the outcome. Therefore, a first step in learning to navigate conflict productively is to let go of the belief that all conflicts can and should be (re)solved. This is also why we emphasize that conflicts can be navigated, not necessarily resolved;
2. Conflict is a **natural part of human collaboration**. It happens to everyone, no matter how skilled you are, how non-violent your communication is, and how considerate you are of others. Conflict in itself is not bad or something that should be avoided. In fact, conflict is a great source of learning and growth, provided we learn how to navigate it productively;
3. **Conflicts don't disappear when we choose to ignore or avoid them** Overwhelmingly, research shows that open-minded conversation is the best way forward. And this is hard. It requires that we learn how to develop and express our ideas and emotions, that we understand and empathize with other views, that we integrate and create new ideas together and that we have to agree to implement relevant solutions (Johnson et al. 2014);
4. Although not all conflicts can be truly solved in the sense of finding a solution, often the act of **talking about it openly** and showing the effect it has on each of us is an important step forward. This will be messy and difficult no matter how skilled you are. And that's fine;

Step 4: Practice Using The Experience Wheel To Address The Elephant In The Room



So far, the participants shared examples of "elephants in the room", and you explained common (mis)beliefs about conflict. Learning how to express annoyances, frustrations, tension, or pinches clearly, is a good way to navigate conflict more effectively. This is where the Experience Wheel comes into play. Whenever you notice a 'pinch', use the Experience Wheel to express your thoughts more clearly by quickly completing four sentences in your head:

- I see ... What are the things I see happening, as factually as possible?
- I feel ... What are you feeling (in one word)?
- I want ... What is your need from the other(s)?
- The story in my head is...your hunch or assumption about what might be going on...

In this step, you explain the Experience Wheel to the participants and help them use it for a real situation themselves.

INVITATION

"What is a real situation where you felt tension or had a conflict and you didn't get the results you needed?"

ONE EXAMPLE

You're feeling uncomfortable/worried/mad because one of your team members has canceled your last three scheduled meetings. Your hunch is that they are ill, or overwhelmed, or being pulled in too many directions. Or maybe they have competing commitments that seem more important than meeting with you. Or maybe you've done something to tick them off.

So it's not necessarily your hunch about what they want, but rather your guess (or the story you've made up) about what might be going on in this situation.

STEPS

- **2 min** Invite participants to think of a real situation where they felt tension or had a conflict and didn't or haven't yet gotten the results they need;
- **10 min** Explain the Experience Wheel you've taped on the floor or shared in a virtual workspace. It helps if you explain each of the steps with a real-life, and personal example.
- **5 min** Ask the participants to individually, and in silence, turn the situation they have in mind into a script for the Experience Wheel.
- **10 min** Form pairs, and invite everyone to share their Experience Wheel and to develop and refine it together. It's not intended to give advice on *how* to use it, but only to improve the quality of the scripted Experience Wheel itself. Maybe certain elements of the Experience Wheel need to be reshuffled, changed, or rewritten. The purpose is to have a good Experience Wheel that can be used for the next step, Troika Consulting.

References

- Gervase Bushe Clear Leadership: How Outstanding Leaders Make Themselves Understood
- Download the [Experience Wheel as a canvas](#) from our webshop for free

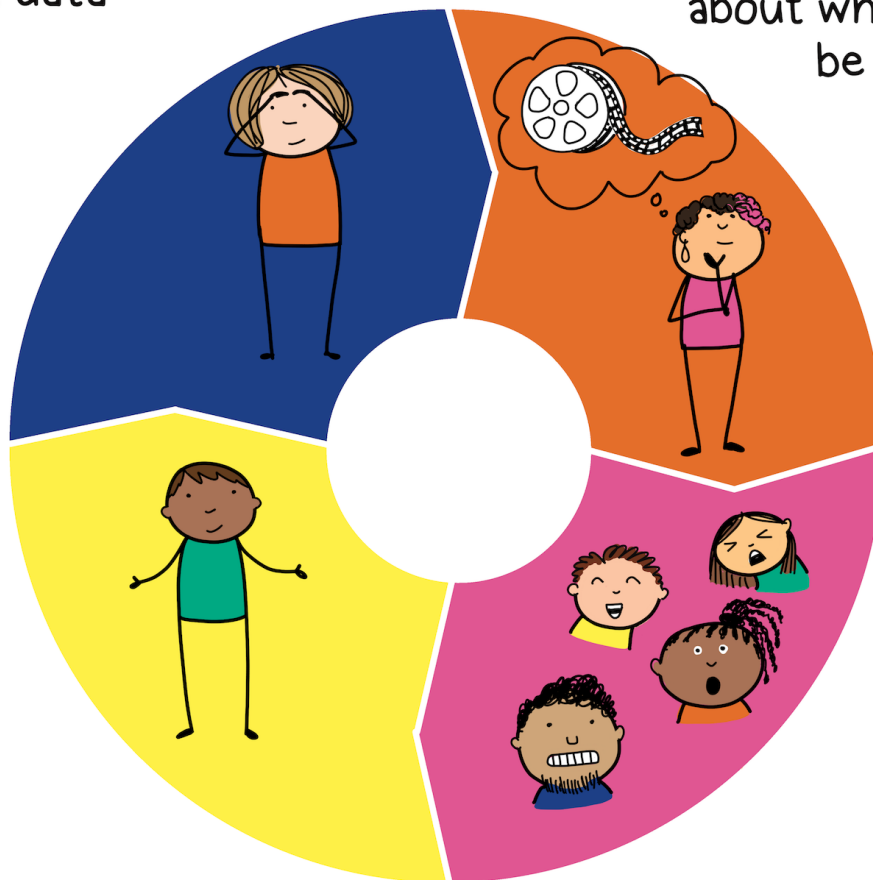


The Experience Wheel

Learn how to address the 'elephant in the room' by clearly expressing observations, feelings, needs, and assumptions

I see ...
observations,
facts, data

The story
in my head is ...
my assumptions
about what might
be going on



I want ...
what is my need from
the other?

What I feel is ...
emotions



Step 5: Give And Get Help With Troika Consulting

In the previous step, everyone created a personal Experience Wheel based on a situation of tension or conflict. In this step, the Liberating Structure [Troika Consulting](#) is used to ask for specific help on how to use the Experience Wheel. It's a very useful Liberating Structure that allows people to ask for help once while giving it twice. It is one of those structures that evoke many smiling faces *and* helpful suggestions.



Invitation

"Share your Experience Wheel and ask for specific help on how to apply it effectively. Given the situation the client shared, what would (s)he need to do in order to navigate the tension or conflict skillfully?"

Steps

1. Explain the steps. Troika Consulting takes three rounds. Everyone will be a "Client" once, with the other two acting as "Consultants".
2. **1 min** Invite people into breakouts of three participants each. Ideally, the groups don't have the same pairs with whom you already shared your Experience Wheel in the previous step.
3. **2 min** Round one starts with the first client sharing his or her Experience Wheel and explaining her specific help request. Consultants ask only clarifying questions.
4. **5 min** Ask the client to turn off their webcam and mute their microphone. Talking only to each other, the consultants generate ideas, suggestions, and coaching advice. In the meantime, the client listens and takes notes.
5. **2 min** The client turns their webcam and microphone back on and shares what was most insightful to them.
6. Groups switch to the next person and repeat the steps.
7. **5 min** Debrief what the experience was like. This is a good opportunity to emphasize that you'll offer much more of these experiences with this meetup.

Our Findings

- Create an overview of the instructions on your virtual whiteboard. People can use this as a reference once they are in their breakouts. Let people self-manage their timeboxes. If you can, broadcast every now and then what round people should be in.
- If the size of your group is not divisible by three, you can create one or two groups of four participants. In those groups, the extra person can give help twice but unfortunately won't be able to get help on their challenge. Ask for volunteers (e.g. people who don't have a clear challenge or don't mind not getting help on their challenge now).

Step 6: Closing

With this workshop, you helped the team to learn how to address the elephant in the room more effectively with the Experience Wheel. It allows you to clearly express observations, feelings, needs, and assumptions and prevents jumping to wrong conclusions.

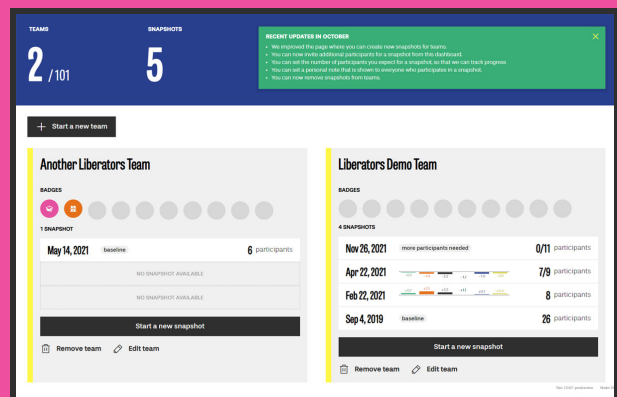
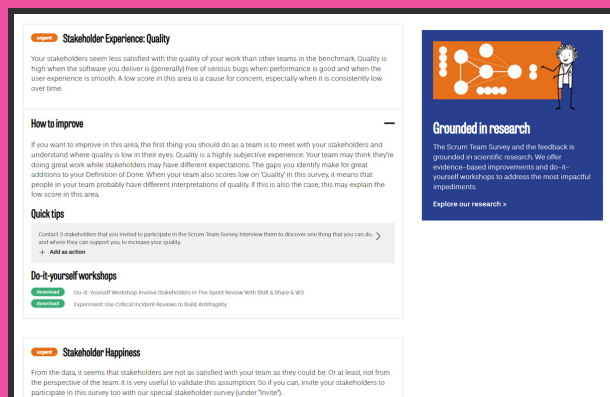
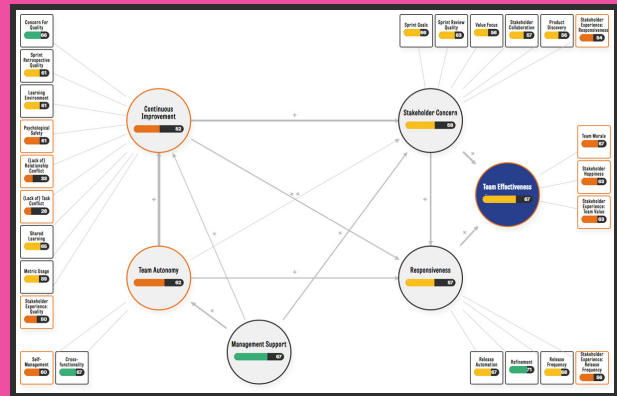
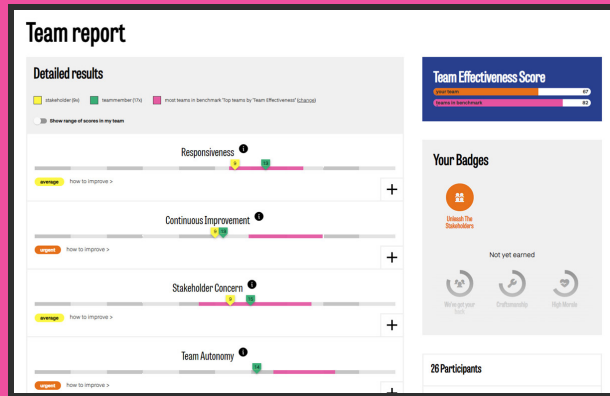
If you've got any questions, comments, or ideas: always feel free to reach out and share them with us.

Let's learn and grow, together!



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